

QUESTION 1

a) Chardonnay

The combination of aromas and flavours from green fruit Wine 1, lemon Wine 3, peach Wine 4 and pineapple Wine 2 point to a variety that can grow in the full range of climates from cool to warm and immediately points to Chardonnay.

The use of winemaking techniques from a high level of buttery notes from malolactic fermentation in Wines 2 and 4, the bread-dough and pastry notes from lees ageing quite prevalent in Wines 1, 3 and 4 are all consistent with Chardonnay.

The varying use of oak from quite subtle French oak in Wine 3, to more overt coconut from American oak in Wine 2, touch of vanilla from old French oak in Wine 1 and more exuberant, fine high toast in Wine 4 consisted with a proportion of New French barriques are all consistent too with Chardonnay.

The acidity levels vary from high in Wines 1 and 4 to quite high in Wine 3 to more moderate in Wine 2 again consistent with the different cool to warm climates of Chardonnay. The alcohol levels too range from 13% Wines 1&4, to 13.5% Wines 2&3 all again in line with Chardonnay.

Finally, the range of qualities from good quality, Wines 2&3 to very good in Wines 1 and 4 are all consistent with the range of quality levels Chardonnay can achieve.

Wine 1

b) Chablis 1er Cru

The subtle aromas of green fruit and crisp lemon point to a cool climate origin such as Chablis.

The very high, racy acidity and 13% alcohol are consistent with this cool climate as are the quite pronounced notes of gunflint, all synonymous with Chablis. The underlying creamy texture is in line with the extended lees ageing often seen with this origin as is the very subtle oak usage to allow the wet stone terroir to shine through. Finally the quite long, chalky finish is in line with a 1er Cru origin. It does not have the depth and length and intense chalky minerality of a Grand Cru site.

c) Very good quality, 1er Cru

The quite concentrated mouthfeel and quite high level of pure citrus and green fruit intensity indicates a very good quality wine, a level up from Village and more in line with 1er Cru. The complex notes of subtle toast, sourdough notes from lees ageing and the quite pronounced mineral and oyster-shell terroir on the finish all point to a more terroir focussed wine and a 1er Cru level Chablis. The wine shows very good balance between the high, racy acidity, 13% alcohol and the quite pure citrus fruit notes. The finish too is quite long. It does not have the intensity, depth of a Grand Cru example but still is very good.

The pale lemon colour and almost predominantly primary notes suggests a young wine of 2-3 years old. There is enough weight for the wine to improve and develop tertiary characters of dried fruit and almond over the next 3-4 years. It then has enough concentration and high acidity to keep a further 5-6 years beyond this.

Wine 2

b) South Africa, Western Cape

The pale golden colour and pronounced notes of mango and pineapple immediately point to a warm New World location and suggest California or South Africa in particular. The quite rich, rounded mouthfeel, 13.5% alcohol and moderate yet refreshing acidity could be consistent with warm regions in both yet the more vanilla rather than coconut aromas from French rather than American oak ageing point more to South Africa over California. The wine lacks the higher level of acidity and more well-defined fruit flavours of a premium region such as Walker Bay or Stellenbosch and the fruit characters seem simpler, more in line with a larger generic origin such as Western Cape. There is a hint of buttery complexity from malolactic fermentation and some subtle toast characters from old oak ageing all in line with a generic style from Western Cape.,

c) Good quality, equivalent to Village Cote Chalonnaise

The wine shows some complexity of butter and toast notes from malolactic and ageing in used French oak. There is a reasonable level of mid-palate concentration and the finish, too, is medium. The fruit is a very tropical and a little one-dimensional in nature but the finish too is medium all suggesting a good quality wine. It is clearly a level up from the basic entry level style and the quite refreshing acidity points to some coastal influence as part of the blend. It lacks the precision of an equivalent Cote d'Or Village wine but would be equivalent to a Cote Chalonnaise in quality. The pale golden colour and very primary tropical fruit indicate a wine of 2-3 years old. The fruit is very straightforward and more designed for immediate drinking than ageing which suggests that it will not improve further from here. However there is enough weight and complexity from oak to indicate the wine will keep at least another 2 - 3 years before fading, all backed up with the medium, fresh acidity.

Wine 3

b) Casablanca, Chile

The combination lemon, peach and quite high lively acidity immediately suggest a cool climate Old World location. However, there is a pure core of ripe, citrus and stone fruit, 13.5% alcohol and a riper mouthfeel without any savoury notes which points to a New World location and Chile in particular. The subtle vanilla from French oak fermentation and ageing and quite yeasty undertone point to a higher quality wine from a premium location and suggest Casablanca or Limari as most likely. Limari would show a little more leanness and a chalkier style from the limestone soils. The wine shows a little more mid palate opulence of the slightly longer hang time yet still cool, coastal fog-influenced location of Casablanca.

c) Good quality, Reserva level

The quite subtle nose of lemon and peach gives way to a richer and more opulent palate which shows a reasonable level of fruit concentration. The flavours are quite well defined and there is complexity too from the integrated toast notes from subtle oak ageing and fermentation and the finish is medium. There is a good balance also between the quite high acidity and 12.5% alcohol and it all points to a good quality, Reserva level.

The pale lemon colour and very primary citrus and stone fruit notes point to a youthful wine of around 2-3 years old. There is not really enough mid palate intensity for the wine to improve from here, however there is enough weight supported by the subtle oak and quite high acidity to allow the wine to keep at least another 2-3 years before decline.

Wine 4

b) Yarra Valley, Australia

The quite pronounced nose of lemon, peach and fine toast from New French oak could immediately point to Meursault or Puligny-Montrachet. The 13% alcohol and quite high and lively acidity could also be consistent with these origins as could the very good quality. The fruit, though, has an extra level of ripeness from Burgundy, with more Meyer lemon and some subtle tropical notes pointing to a slightly warmer New World location and suggesting Australia or New Zealand in particular. The wine shows a flinty and reductive undertone which could be consistent with both these locations and the acidity is not quite high enough for the slightly cooler Auckland or Central Otago and there is a savoury note from possible natural yeast fermentation suggesting Australia and Yarra Valley in particular. Margaret River was also considered but the body would show more breadth and depth and slightly lower acidity, leaving the cooler climate Yarra Valley as most likely.

c) Very good quality, equivalent to Village Level Puligny-Montrachet

The wine shows a pure citrus and stone fruit concentration. There is complexity from a very wide range of flavours from lemon to mango and a diverse range of winemaking techniques, subtle cream and sourdough from partial malolactic and extended lees ageing. The fine toast and very integrated vanilla and peach nature indicates a portion of new French oak, likely 20%, for both fermentation and ageing. The finish too is quite long and persistent, testament to the very good quality. It all points to a very good example, one equivalent to a very good Village Level Puligny Montrachet.

The lemon colour and notes of citrus, peach and oak with no tertiary dried fruit characters indicate a very youthful wine of 1-2 years old. The wine is taut and tightly wound and has enough

concentration to improve over the next 3-4 years when the new French oak will integrate fully and the fruit will open out. It will then hold for another 4-5 years supported by the elevated acidity before decline.

QUESTION 2

Wine 5

a) Soave Classico, Veneto

The subtle floral nose of elderflower and jasmine with notes of pear and quince could suggest a number of varieties including Pinot Grigio, Cortese or Garganega. The acidity is high and racy in line with all three as is the modest alcohol at 12%. However there is a noticeable camomile and almond finish in line with the more herbal and nutty profile of Garganega and confirms this as the variety.

The unique variety points to Soave as the location and the structure of high acidity, 12% alcohol and floral and citrus characters are in line with this northerly and quite cool climate. However there is some complexity from wet stone, smokiness as well as some creamy texture from lees ageing which elevates it to a more premium location and suggests the more volcanic soils of Soave Classico.

b) A complex, dry, creamy textured, volcanic and unoaked style of wine. One that is intended for immediate drinking but will reward keeping in the short term.

A good quality Soave Classico, as seen by the moderate pure citrus fruit concentration with quite precise and direct citrus fruit some flavours. There is complexity from the creamy texture and the wet stone, volcanic notes. It shows very good balance between the high, crisp acidity, 12% alcohol and moderate fruit intensity. The finish too is medium all suggesting a good quality, Classico example.

A creamy textured and slightly mineral, Classico style which indicates good rather than acceptable quality wine wine retailing for around \$25 per bottle. The slightly higher price point means it will be above the inexpensive and more one-dimensional entry level styles of Soave and therefore available in more limited distribution. It will appeal to those consumers who love crisp, dry, unoaked wines but in this case with some personality and mineral complexity. It could therefore be a good alternative to other neutral Italian white varieties or indeed other high acid varieties such as Chenin Blanc, Grüner Veltliner or Albariño. It will most likely be sold in premium supermarkets rather than discounters, as well as Canadian and Scandinavian Monopolies and more premium On Trade and Multiple Specialists..

Wine 6

a) Pinot Grigio, Veneto

The pale water-white colour and simple, one-dimensional citrus and green fruit immediately suggest Pinot Grigio. The light body, high, crisp acidity and 12.5% alcohol are all consistent with the high volume styles of this variety from delle Venezie as is the quite short finish. The lack of any real complexity from oak or lees ageing are all consistent with these simple styles from the Veneto.

b) A very simple, dry, easy-drinking, uncomplicated yet refreshing wine, one intended for immediate consumption

The wine is well balanced between the high acidity and the light body but it is still very simple and straightforward in style. It is quite one-dimensional, with very modest citrus fruit characters, no complexity from any winemaking techniques and quite a short finish.

The simple style and dry, high acidity and subtle floral and citrus nature indicate an entry level wine selling for around \$12. It will therefore appeal to a wide audience of wine drinkers looking for a crisp, dry white wine on a strict budget and at a keen price point. The very approachable, neutral nature of the wine indicate its will be widely available to the mass market consumer in multiple outlets such as supermarkets, convenience stores and On Trade chains. It lends itself

perfectly to multiple forms of packaging from bottle and bag-in-box to cans and could also be suitable as a mixer with fruit based drinks.

Wine 7

a) Greco, Greco di Tufo

The pale golden colour and notes of greengage, quince and peach could suggest a number of varieties such as Fiano, Garganega or Greco. The alcohol 13% is consistent with all these though the acidity is high and too crisp for most Fiano. The wine has quite a phenolic edge, full body and a smoky undertone which is more in line with the volcanic nature of Greco over the more herbal, camomile notes often found with Garganega. This unique variety and smoky note suggests one location, Greco di Tufo in Campania.

b) A full bodied, complex, dry, volcanic and quite intense style. A wine that will keep in the medium term.

A very good quality Riserva level. The palate is very complex with notes of wild flowers, greengage, creaminess and a smoky volcanic edge. There is a high level of stone fruit concentration and the wine is underpinned with surprisingly high and refreshing acidity which is well balanced with the 13% alcohol, all consistent with a very good quality wine. This together with the fairly long finish all indicates a level above generic and points to a Riserva quality. The complex, full bodied and smoky nature suggests a wine selling for around \$40. The ripe fruit characters with notes of peach and apricot together with the dry style means it will appeal to this that love fuller-bodied premium wines from Chardonnay to Viognier. The high crisp acidity, though, provides an unusual refreshing profile for such a full bodied wine. The very unfamiliar grape variety and location means it will be sold predominantly in its own region of Campania but will find export markets particularly in USA and UK in Independent Specialist and higher end, likely Italian restaurants where the style can be recommended.

QUESTION 3

Wine 8

a) The very pale colour and gentle notes of orange blossom, green apple and grapefruit suggest a wine from a cool climate to give this subtly aromatic style. The modest alcohol 11.5%, off-dry style, high crisp acidity and light body are consistent with this cooler climate and contribute to produce this very approachable and floral wine. The emphasis on primary fruit flavours with no trace of vanilla and toast suggest the wine was fermented in stainless steel rather than oak to preserve the primary aromatics of the grape varieties, likely at cool temperatures 15-16C. The very integrated nature points to a likely co-fermentation of the varieties to produce the very light, harmonious style and the 4g/l RS indicates fermentation stopped just before the end, possibly naturally. The light body, lack of any oxidative notes and water-white colour indicate a wine that has undergone a very short period of ageing in stainless steel, 3-4 months, to create this very approachable, straightforward, early drinking style.

b) A good quality wine that shows a modest amount of concentration. It does though show some complexity from the array of primary fruit flavours from floral to citrus and green olive. It is very well balanced between the high acidity, off-dry style and modest alcohol and the finish is medium. This is a wine that could be marketed as a much more aromatic alternative to less expressive crisp, slightly drier white wines such as Muscadet sur Lie or Pinot Grigio. The quite high degree of aromatics for such a straightforward wine means it could cross the divide between the Pinot Grigio, Sauvignon Blanc or Albariño drinker, probably for an equally attractive price point of around £9. The modest alcohol 11.5% means it is also on trend for those looking for lower alcohol wines and it could therefore be marketed as an adventurous choice for the less risk-averse consumer.

Wine 9 - CORKED (Tried to ignore the TCA and write an objective note)

a) The very ripe fruit flavours from candied lemon, to white peach, mango and walnut suggest a relatively warm and dry climate to produce this more intense and rounded style. The alcohol 13.5% would seem to suggest a sheltered, steep, southerly facing location to achieve this full

bodied, ripe style with the moderately crisp acidity coming from diurnal shift and cooler night-time temperatures. The distinct saline and chalky finish suggests a granitic and likely limestone soil allowing the powerful terroir, wet stone notes to shine through.

The very pure citrus and stone fruit characters with no phenolic edge suggest a whole bunch pressing and the pronounced vanilla and toast point to likely fermentation in French oak barriques to give this more harmonious oaked style. The integrated buttery notes indicates that full malolactic took place in barrel and the very creamy texture points to ageing on lees for around 12 months. The fine toast on the finish confirms ageing in the same French oak barriques, likely 30% new, to give this very complex, fine toast and nutty style.

b) Outstanding quality, special cuvée \$150

The very pure floral peach flavours and complex nature from barrel fermentation and ageing suggest an outstanding quality wine, likely around \$150 retail. The wine shows great intensity and precision and a very high degree of complexity from the barrel fermentation, ageing, malolactic and powerful terroir notes. The finish too is long all consistent with the outstanding quality.

The wide range of aromas and flavours mean it could be marketed as an alternative to other prestigious white wine blends such as GCC White Bordeaux or top quality white Châteauneuf-du-Pape. Likely from a well known origin for red wines this less familiar white style is a wine that could be positioned as a line extension to these more popular red styles. However, it will probably be made in more limited quantities and therefore possibly be sold at a slightly higher price. Despite the lack of familiarity it could be more highly prized due to its rarity. The high degree of complexity and long ageing potential means it would also be suitable for collectors but could also be a great Fine Wine by the glass option in prestigious On Trade establishments, particularly under Coravin.

QUESTION 4

Wine 10

a) Marlborough, New Zealand. Sauvignon Blanc

The pronounced nose of freshly cut grass, lemon, and passion fruit together with high crisp acidity and dry style immediately suggest Sauvignon Blanc as the variety. There is too much ripeness and tropical fruit for the Loire pointing more to New World. The very overt characters suggest South Africa or New Zealand as most likely but the very pungent nature is too strong even for South Africa and suggests New Zealand and Marlborough in particular. The 13.5% alcohol and very leesy texture are consistent with premium examples of this variety.

b) Very good quality, special cuvée

The wine shows the typical gooseberry and passion fruit notes of a Marlborough Sauvignon Blanc but has much more complexity than the generic examples. The wild, sauvage overtone and very savoury palate indicate likely fermentation with natural yeast and further complexity from the subtle oxidative notes from partial oak ageing. The fruit is pure and very concentrated and the finish too is quite long all further testament to the very good quality. It may stop short of the very top examples but shows how this popular style can evolve into a more serious and age worthy wine.

C) A complex, wild yeast fermented, oak aged and complex style.

This more complex, oak aged style means it will find favour with more engaged and inquisitive consumers willing to spend \$40 on a NZ Sauvignon Blanc. It will therefore be much more limited in appeal and likely sold mostly through Independent Wine Merchants and Premium On Trade. It can be marketed as a more serious wine to compete with premium Sancerre or Pouilly-Fumé and could be positioned as a wine that can age rather than for immediate drinking more typical of the generic Marlborough Sauvignon Blanc styles.

Wine 11

a) Pfalz, Germany. Riesling

The pale lemon colour and very expressive nose of elderflower, green apple, apricot and peach suggest Riesling or Chenin Blanc as the variety. The medium-dry style could be consistent with both yet the alcohol 9.5% is too low for Chenin Blanc and the high, tensile acidity too extreme for most Chenin Blancs leaving Riesling as most likely. The hint of petrol too is more in line with Riesling. The medium-dry nature with 50g/l RS, high acidity and 9.5% alcohol points to Germany

as the origin. It has a combination of clean citrus characters and riper stone fruit notes suggesting a warmer origin than the cooler and lighter Mosel suggesting either Rheingau or Pfalz. The medium-dry style would generally be more common in Rheingau but the predominance of stone fruit notes would seem to suggest the slightly warmer Pfalz as most likely.

b) Good quality Kabinett, Gutswein

The wine is good quality with well defined and quite intense citrus and stone fruit notes. There is excellent balance between the high, taut acidity and medium-dry style, 50g/l RS. There is subtle complexity from the range of primary fruit flavours, from elderflower, citrus to peach, and the finish, too, is medium. There is elegance and poise which further confirm a good quality Kabinett. It lacks the extra length, mineral, terroir intensity and depth of an Erste or Grosse Lage site suggesting more likely a Gutswein from a very reputable Estate.

c) A light bodied, medium-dry, quite complex, very invigorating Kabinett style.

The medium-dry nature and good quality indicate a wine selling for around \$25. The highly integrated level of sweetness means it could still appeal to those drinkers who prefer drier rather than sweeter wines and for ones looking for exquisite balance to offset the very high acidity. It is still likely to be more popular outside its native Germany where demand for the pure Trocken styles is strong, but it could find outlets in export markets such as Asia where the medium-dry style and high crisp acidity can be a perfect foil for the spicy cuisine. The established market of the UK could also be a renewed target with the 9.5% alcohol now attracting lower duty rates and therefore a more competitive retail price point.

Wine 12

a) **Salta, Argentina. Torrontes**

The very pronounced orange blossom, fresh grape and citronella aromas point straight to the highly aromatic Torrontes. The medium body, quite high, crisp acidity and alcohol 13.5% are all in line with this location. The very pure floral and grape characters and more phenolic edge point to the very high altitude and higher UV climate of Salta over the slightly less aromatic and less pungent wines of Mendoza.

b) A good quality wine, likely an Estate level example.

There is a some degree of complexity from the quite wide array of primary aromas : floral, grape and peach together with a slightly creamy texture from some lees ageing. The wine has a very good balance between the 13.5 % alcohol and quite high acidity and the finish is medium. It all points to a good quality wine. It lacks the extra concentration, complexity and length of an old vines or single vineyard example, pointing more towards a good Estate level wine.

c) A very aromatic, moderately complex, high altitude, and very approachable style of Torrontés.

This very aromatic and subtly complex style suggests a retail price of around \$16. It will therefore appeal to the budget conscious consumer looking for interesting and unusual dry white wines at an affordable price point. It could be marketed at those consumers that love highly aromatic wines from Sauvignon Blanc to Riesling and Muscat. The unusual variety and very unfamiliar locality means it could well be more suitable to Multiple Specialists and On trade chains where recommendation is key. Some higher end supermarkets could also be potential outlets particularly if the wine has garnered favourable wine critic ratings which could be used via shelf barkers in-store. The very refreshing, unoaked style lends itself perfectly to screw cap closure too.